

The Massachusetts Permit Mistakes Checklist

10 errors that get applications rejected - and how to avoid them | PermitIQ

1. Starting work before the permit is issued

Most MA towns double the fee for unpermitted work; Malden and Taunton triple it, Medford quadruples it, and Methuen charges 300% plus \$100 to lift the stop-work order.

2. Assuming every town charges the same fee

Rates range from \$10 to \$20+ per \$1,000 of project value, with different minimums, application fees, and plan-review surcharges town by town. Budget from YOUR town's schedule.

3. Undervaluing the project on the application

Inspectors check stated value against signed contracts and cost guides like RS Means. Undervaluing can trigger the same penalty as skipping the permit (Boston doubles the fee).

4. Forgetting trade permits ride along with the building permit

A kitchen remodel usually needs separate electrical, plumbing, and gas permits, each with its own licensed applicant, fee, and inspection schedule.

5. Missing the zoning review before applying

Setbacks, lot coverage, and accessory-structure rules are local bylaws. A permit application that violates zoning is rejected no matter how good the drawings are.

6. Skipping the Home Improvement Contractor (HIC) paperwork

For contracted residential work, many towns require the contractor's HIC registration and a signed contract copy with the application.

7. Not booking inspections in the town's required windows

Many building departments only take inspection calls in narrow morning windows, and a missed appointment can cost a re-inspection fee (\$50-\$75 in most towns).

8. Letting the permit expire mid-project

Permits typically lapse after 6-12 months of inactivity. Renewals cost money (Peabody: \$125/year) and can subject the project to newer code requirements.

9. Skipping the certificate of occupancy

Occupying without a CO is a separate violation (Lawrence fines \$300). The CO also has its own fee and final-inspection requirements - plan for it from day one.

10. Trusting generic internet answers over the town's own schedule

State code (780 CMR) is uniform; fees, forms, and quirks are not. Verify against your town's published fee schedule - or use a tool that cites it - before you file.

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